2.1 Expanding into Native American Lands

Native Americans had lived in North America for centuries, enduring natural disasters, wars, and disease. Soon they would be forced to try to survive Andrew Jackson's Native American policies.

MAIN IDEA Native Americans lost land to white settlers as Andrew Jackson and the U.S. government forced their westward relocation.

TREATIES AND BATTLES

Andrew Jackson had a long history with Native Americans. After the War of 1812, he battled the Creek in Georgia and negotiated a treaty with them on behalf of the federal government. According to the terms of the treaty, the Creek gave up 22 million acres of land (an area larger than the state of South Carolina) to the government, which then sold pieces of the land to settlers.

More battles and treaties followed with the Creek, Cherokee, Choctaw, and Chickasaw, who held large areas of land throughout the South. Little by little, many of these groups were forced onto lands less suited to farming, as white settlers moved into what had once been Native American territory.

When Jackson became president, he offered Native Americans in the South two choices: either **assimilate**, or adopt, European ways of life and accept the authority of the states in which they lived, or move west of the Mississippi River. More than any other southeastern tribe, the Cherokee assimilated, taking up many aspects of white culture and customs. They dressed in western-style clothing and built plantations and ranches similar to those of white settlers.

One Cherokee named **Sequoya** (sih-KWOY-uh) developed a writing system and began publishing a newspaper. As a result, literacy quickly spread among the Cherokee. They even wrote a constitution, using the U.S. Constitution as a model, and established the **Cherokee Nation**. Despite these efforts, the Cherokee were under constant pressure to leave the region. The pressure came to a head in 1828, when Americans discovered gold on Cherokee lands in Georgia. Now both settlers and miners were eager to grab the land. That's when southern states passed laws allowing them to take over Native American lands.

THE INDIAN REMOVAL ACT

Jackson supported these laws and, in 1830, approved another law that took Native American relocation a step further. The law was the **Indian Removal Act**, which ended the U.S. government's earlier policy of respecting the rights of Native Americans to remain on land they'd lived on for generations. Under this policy, they were forced to move to an area of land that included present-day Oklahoma and parts of Kansas and Nebraska. The area came to be known as **Indian Territory**.

The act required the government to peacefully negotiate treaties with Native Americans and not force them off their land. But the U.S. government and Jackson often ignored this requirement. Jackson considered Native Americans conquered subjects of the United States. As such, he believed the government could decide where they would live.

Not all Americans supported the removal act. Many opposed it because of their dislike of Jackson. Others protested the cruelty of sending Native Americans into an unknown wilderness. Religious groups, such as the Quakers, opposed the act on moral grounds, claiming it wasn't just or right. Many Native Americans gave in and left their homes. But not all would go without a fight.

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National Museum of the American Indian, Washington, D.C.

While the Cherokee assimilated European styles, they also held onto their own culture, as the traditional artifacts shown here demonstrate. The man's coat is made from the hide of deer, which the Cherokee hunted. Like all Cherokee baskets, the one shown here was woven by a woman and was used to store all sorts of household goods. The Cherokee would have filled the wooden water drum with a quantity of water to get a deep, echoing sound.



Man's coat, c. 1820



Water drum and drumstick, c. 1890

Basket of woven and dyed rivercane, c. 1900



HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was Jackson's attitude toward Native Americans?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** What do you think the Cherokee hoped to gain by establishing their own constitution?
3. **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** How were the stated policies toward Native Americans different from what actually occurred?

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